

stuck his furniture in a friend's garage, his private papers in his mother's closet, and his clothes in a suitcase. Harold is quiet and careful no longer. He's as excited about his new life as a car dealer with next year's models.

Harold thinks he needs another \$100,000 of net worth to stay retired for good. He plans to try the south of France for three years and see how his money holds out. Later on, he can go back to work or move to cheaper Spain or Portugal.

Sarah is 48. One morning fifteen years ago she woke up in her Westchester home and found her husband had abandoned her and their three kids. Within a week she had two jobs—the first two jobs of her life—and took in boarders. For fifteen years she worked to put her kids through school and keep peanut butter on the table. And over those fifteen years her home equity grew to half a million dollars.

The turning point came last year when Sarah's "baby" graduated from college. Sarah decided she had reached her limit of fifteen- and twenty-hour days. She quit both jobs, cashed out of the big house, put the money in the bank, and packed up. She headed first for South America, where her son works at an archaeological dig. I hope she writes to tell me where she goes next. Vicki and I might try to meet up with her.

Perry is 54, married, and has a daughter in college and a 14-year-old son at home. He was president of the Brazil subsidiary of a New York bank. Three years ago I called his office and was told he was at home with a stomachache. I called home and was told he was in the hospital with arrhythmia. Perry was glad to see me when I showed up at the hospital, but he swore me to secrecy. Not even his secretary knew his real problem was with his heart. If anyone in the company learned the truth about his health, he could be passed over for promotion.

I told him he was 54 and should think about retiring rather